Translating the moral and ideological critique into sustainable politics is the next task at hand."

The real challenge for the Congress begins once the yatra ends on January 30. Not only will it have to keep the momentum it has generated going but also build on it. Especially if it has to effectively take on the juggernaut that the BJP has become under the stewardship of Narendra Modi and Amit Shah. Having realised the importance of doing so, the Congress is starting a 'Haath Se Haath Jodo' campaign from January 26 to March 26. Intended to carry forward the message of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, the campaign will see party workers fanning out to cover 230,000 gram panchayats, 600,000 villages and 1 million electoral booths across the country. Psephologist Pradeep Gupta, founder of Axis My India, though, cautions the Congress against expecting quick results from the yatra. "What the yatra has done," says Gupta, "is planted a seed. The Congress organisation must nurture the seed and make radical changes in the organisation for it to grow and reap the fruits of the yatra."

WANTED: AN ORGANISATIONAL REVAMP

Most Congress veterans agree that the yatra has enthused party workers—a key objective of the mission. "I have never seen such euphoria among workers in my entire political career. The BJY has infused a different kind of energy into the organisation," says Kamal Nath, former Madhya Pradesh CM and nine-time Lok Sabha MP. But the party must now build the organisation to sustain this energy. This will be the challenge for newly elected president Kharge. Vacant posts need to be filled, particularly in election-bound states. For instance, 20 out of the 31 district units in Rajasthan have been functioning without a president.

The wait is now for the plenary session of the Congress scheduled in February in Raipur. A new Congress Working Committee (CWC), the highest decision-making body, will be formed after this session. The structure and style of functioning of the new CWC will determine the future of the Congress. "The Congress must change the composition of the top executives such as the CWC," says Rahul Verma. "It must get rid of old leaders and infuse young blood if it wishes to connect with the youth." For now, Kharge has served an ultimatum to Congress general secretaries and state unit observers to visit their assigned workplaces for 10 days a month to get feedback and streamline things down to the district and block levels. At the party's steering committee meeting held on December 4, Kharge told party office-bearers to either shape up or ship out.

Experts believe that the Congress, with nearly 20 per cent vote share nationally, still has an edge over other Opposition parties. "The yatra's real test is if it can convert that 20 per cent into a better strike rate, winning more seats, and make further additions to the vote share. The Congress must follow up with organisational rebuilding and regular outreach if it doesn't want to fritter away the advantages of the yatra," says Professor Narender Kumar, chairperson, CPS, JNU. Importantly, Rahul Gandhi and the senior leaders should now finalise an alternative narrative offering concrete solutions to the economic, social and political issues that they raised in the yatra.

Rahul, for instance, talked broadly about the economic reforms he would focus on, including boosting the micro, small and medium industries to provide jobs to millions apart from supplementing farmers' incomes by establishing a solid agro-processing network. He also said he was against privatisation of public sector companies because he believes they should be treated not just as assets to be sold but as means of people's empowerment. When it came to welfare measures, his focus would be access and equity rather than just efficiency. He also reiterated the 2019 poll promise of NYAY, the scheme that assured the 50 million poorest families in the country of a guaranteed cash

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